



Free to All

Student copy (project or hand out)

- 1 There is a building in almost every town that will take you in and ask for nothing. You do not have to buy anything. You do not have to believe anything. You do not have to be anyone in particular. Over the door of one of them, in Boston, three words are cut into the stone: Free to All. We built thousands of these, and then half forgot that we had.
- 2 Think of who is inside on a cold afternoon. A child carries a stack of books taller than her arms. A man with nowhere warmer to be reads the paper front to back, because the room is his too. Someone fills out the forms that will decide a year of their life, and a librarian leans in to help, for nothing. It is the smallest thing a town builds, and close to the largest in what it hands out.
- 3 The promise is strange when you say it plainly. Walk in with a question, any question, and a person whose job is to care about the answer will help you find it. The library does not ask whether the question is worth asking. A scholar and a kid doing a report on volcanoes get the same patient attention and the same chair. The building keeps no record of which of them deserved it.
- 4 And it does all this quietly, without a slogan, without a campaign, without anyone needing to be persuaded that a warm room and a free book and a person who knows where to look might be worth keeping, which is perhaps why it has been so easy to let the hours shrink and the branches dim while we were busy admiring louder things. The library has never been good at advertising itself.
- 5 So before we let it go without thanks, it is worth saying plainly what it was: a place that believed, in brick and oak and a stamped card, that a person's worth did not depend on their purse. We will not build many things like that again. The lights are still on, in most towns, for now.

AP-style multiple choice:

1. In the first paragraph, the repetition of 'You do not have to' (buy anything, believe anything, be anyone in particular) primarily serves to
 - A) convey that the library places no condition of any kind on who may enter
 - B) list the specific services the library provides to its visitors
 - C) criticize people who expect public spaces to charge a fee
 - D) trace the steps a visitor follows to obtain a library card
2. Which of the following best characterizes the writer's overall stance toward the public library?
 - A) reverent esteem for an institution the writer treats as plainly worth keeping
 - B) cautious optimism that the library can modernize enough to survive
 - C) a balanced weighing of the library's costs against its public benefits
 - D) nostalgic regret for an institution the writer says has already vanished

Discussion questions:

1. The writer praises the library entirely through concrete scenes (a child with a stack of books, a man with nowhere warmer to be) rather than through adjectives like 'important' or 'valuable.' What does the piece gain by showing the library's worth this way instead of asserting it?
2. The closing line says the lights are 'still on, in most towns, for now.' How do those three small qualifications change the feeling of the ending, even though the writer never issues a warning or a call to action?

Writing prompt (homework or extended in-class, Q2 rhetorical analysis):

Write an essay analyzing how the writer uses concrete detail, repetition, and understatement to honor the public library and to suggest, without ever stating it, that the institution is at risk.